Actions and Tools – Technical Documentation

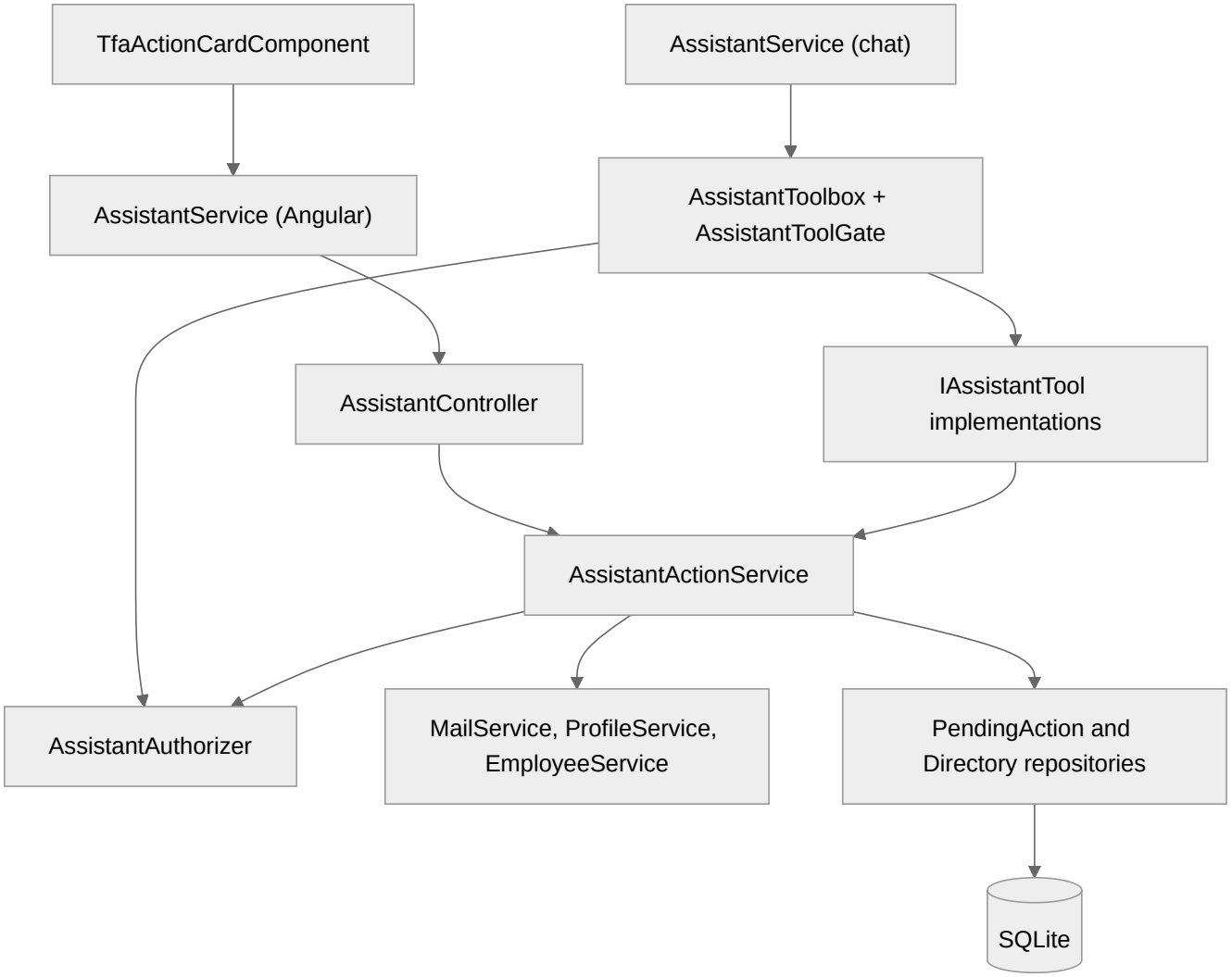
Project: TaskFlow – Intelligent Task Allocation & Tracking System
Parent Module: TaskFlow Assistant (TFA) · **Child Module:** 09.2 Actions and Tools
Version: 1.0 · **Last Updated:** 31-Oct-2026
Backend: ASP.NET Core Web API (.NET 10) · **Frontend:** Angular · **Database:** SQLite (EF Core)
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1. Technical Overview

Actions and Tools covers the model-callable tools and the pending-action lifecycle. `Services/Assistant/Tools` holds 9 `IAssistantTool` implementations (6 read/guidance tools, 3 action-preparing tools). `AssistantToolbox` advertises only tools the caller may use and re-checks authorization on every call through `AssistantToolGate` → `IAssistantAuthorizer`, which evaluates the API's own `perm:{key}` authorization policies.

Action tools only create an `AssistantPendingAction` (10-minute lifetime) through `AssistantActionService`. Only the user's `POST actions/{id}/confirm` executes it, after re-checking the policy with the caller's current token and atomically claiming the row (`TryClaimAsync`), so it runs at most once. The Angular `TfaActionCardComponent` renders the card with Confirm / Edit / Cancel.

2. Architecture Flow



3. Backend File Structure

Layer	Path	Files
Controller	`TaskFlow.Api/Controllers/Assistant/`	`AssistantController.cs` (action endpoints, `RunActionAsync`)
Service – Actions	`TaskFlow.Api/Services/Assistant/Actions/`	`IAssistantActionService.cs`, `IAssistantActionCards.cs`, `AssistantActionService.cs`
Service – Tools	`TaskFlow.Api/Services/Assistant/Tools/`	`IAssistantTool.cs`, `AssistantReadTools.cs` (`AssistantTaskReader`, `GetMyTasksTool`, `PrioritiseTasksTool`, `SearchHelpTool`, `FindUserTool`, `ExplainPasswordChangeTool`, `ContactAdminGuidanceTool`), `AssistantActionTools.cs` (`AssistantUserResolver`, `AssistantManagerResolver`, `DraftMailTool`, `ProposeProfileUpdateTool`, `ProposeRoleChangeTool`)

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Layer	Path	Files
Service – Toolbox	`TaskFlow.Api/Services/Assistant/Toolbox/`	`IAssistantToolbox.cs`, `AssistantToolbox.cs` (also `AssistantToolGate`), `ToolOutcome.cs`
Service – Rules	`TaskFlow.Api/Services/Assistant/Rules/`	`AssistantActionRules.cs`, `TaskPrioritiser.cs`
Repository	`TaskFlow.Api/Repositories/Assistant/`	`PendingActions/IAssistantPendingActionRepository.cs`, `AssistantPendingActionRepository.cs`; `People/IAssistantDirectoryRepository.cs`, `AssistantDirectoryRepository.cs`
DTOs	`TaskFlow.Api/Dtos/Assistant/`	`AssistantActionDtos.cs` (`SendMailPayload`, `UpdateProfilePayload`, `ChangeRolePayload`, `MailRecipientRef`, `EditMailActionRequest`, `AssistantActionResultDto`, `ResolvedUser`); `AssistantDtos.cs` (`AssistantPendingActionDto`, `AssistantActionFieldDto`)
Validators	(reused) `Dtos/Communication/Mail/Validators/`, `Dtos/Profile/Validators/`	`SendMailRequestValidator` (in `MailRequestValidators.cs`), `UpdateOwnProfileRequestValidator.cs` – no TFA-specific validator class
Entities	`TaskFlow.Api/Models/Entities/`	`AssistantPendingAction.cs`
Enums	`TaskFlow.Api/Models/Enums/`	`AssistantActionKind.cs`, `AssistantActionStatus.cs`
Authorization	`TaskFlow.Api/Authorization/Assistant/`	`IAssistantAuthorizer.cs`, `AssistantAuthorizer.cs`
Exceptions	`TaskFlow.Api/Common/Exceptions/`	`AssistantExceptions.cs` (`AssistantActionConflictException`, `AssistantRequestException`)

> `SearchHelpTool` delegates to the Help Knowledge base (09.3).

4. Frontend File Structure

Type	Path	Purpose
Child components	`src/app/modules/assistant/components/tfa-action-card.component.ts/.html`	Pending action card: Confirm / Edit / Cancel, mail edit form, status labels
Child components	`src/app/modules/assistant/components/tfa-message.component.ts/.html`	Hosts the action card inside a message
API service	`src/app/modules/assistant/services/assistant.service.ts`	Edit / confirm / cancel HTTP calls

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Type	Path	Purpose
Models	`src/app/modules/assistant/models/assistant.model.ts`, `services/assistant.model.ts`	Action card and result interfaces
Permission constants	`src/app/shared/auth/permissions.ts`	`AssistantActions: 'assistant.actions.confirm'` (not referenced by any component – see Gaps)

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5. API & Logic

5.1 API Endpoints

#	Method	Endpoint	Description	Permission (Policy)	Request DTO	Response DTO
1	PUT	`/api/v1/assistant/actions/{id:guid}`	Edit a pending mail's recipients, subject, body	`perm:assistant.actions.confirm`	`EditMailActionRequest`	`AssistantPendingActionDto` (404 if not the caller's)
2	POST	`/api/v1/assistant/actions/{id:guid}/confirm`	Execute the prepared action (only path that runs an action)	`perm:assistant.actions.confirm` (+ `perm:roles.manage` re-checked in service for `ChangeUserRole`)	–	`AssistantActionResultDto` (404 if not the caller's)
3	POST	`/api/v1/assistant/actions/{id:guid}/cancel`	Cancel a pending action	`perm:assistant.actions.confirm`	–	`AssistantPendingActionDto` (404 if not the caller's)

All endpoints also carry the class-level `[Authorize]` (JWT).

Model tools (not HTTP endpoints; invoked by the model inside `SendAsync`, 09.1):

Tool name	Class	Policy	Arguments (JSON Schema)	Effect
`get_my_tasks`	`GetMyTasksTool`	none (signed-in)	`filter` (upcoming, due_today, overdue, all_open), `scope` (mine, accessible), `limit` (default 10, max 20)	Read open tasks via `ITaskService.ListAsync(filter, userId, role)`; links `/tasks/{id}`
`prioritise_tasks`	`PrioritiseTasksTool`	none	`limit` (default 5, max 10)	`TaskPrioritiser.Rank` on own open tasks; returns `RankedTasks`
`search_help`	`SearchHelpTool`	none	`topic` (required)	`IHelpKnowledgeBase.Search(topic, role)` (09.3)
`find_user`	`FindUserTool`	none	`name` (required)	`IMailService.GetContactsAsync` (max 10)

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Tool name	Class	Policy	Arguments (JSON Schema)	Effect
`explain_password_change`	`ExplainPasswordChangeTool`	none	–	Fixed `PasswordGuidance` reply + `/profile` link
`contact_admin_guidance`	`ContactAdminGuidanceTool`	none	–	Fixed `AdminGuidance` reply
`draft_mail`	`DraftMailTool`	none	`recipient` ("manager"), `to[]`, `taskId`, `subject`, *`body`*	Creates `SendMail` pending action
`propose_profile_update`	`ProposeProfileUpdateTool`	none	`fullName`, `email`	Creates `UpdateOwnProfile` pending action
`propose_role_change`	`ProposeRoleChangeTool`	`perm:roles.manage`	`user`, *`role`*	Creates `ChangeUserRole` pending action

No tool accepts a user id, role or password; the caller is always `AssistantCaller` built from the JWT claims (`ClaimTypes.NameIdentifier`, `ClaimTypes.Role`).

5.2 Request / Response Samples

```
// PUT /api/v1/assistant/actions/3f2b0c1e-9a7d-4c55-8f0e-1b2c3d4e5f60
{ "to": ["ravi@company.com"], "subject": "TSK-12 update", "body": "Hi Ravi, ..." }
```

```
// 200 OK
{ "id": "3f2b0c1e-9a7d-4c55-8f0e-1b2c3d4e5f60", "kind": "SendMail", "status": "Pending",
  "expiresAt": "2026-10-31T10:10:00Z", "title": "Mail draft",
  "fields": [ { "label": "To", "value": "Ravi Kumar <ravi@company.com>" }, { "label":
"Subject", "value": "TSK-12 update" } ],
  "body": "Hi Ravi, ...", "canEdit": true }
```

```
// POST /api/v1/assistant/actions/3f2b0c1e-9a7d-4c55-8f0e-1b2c3d4e5f60/confirm – 200 OK
{ "id": "3f2b0c1e-9a7d-4c55-8f0e-1b2c3d4e5f60", "status": "Confirmed",
  "message": "Done. Your mail \"TSK-12 update\" was sent to Ravi Kumar.",
  "reply": { "id": 57, "role": "Assistant", "content": "Done. Your mail \"TSK-12 update\" was
sent to Ravi Kumar.",
    "kind": "Text", "createdAt": "2026-10-31T10:02:00Z", "provider": null, "links": [],
"rankedTasks": [], "action": null } }
```

```
// 409 Conflict (problem details)
{ "status": 409, "title": "This action can no longer be done", "detail": "This request has
expired. Please ask TFA again." }
```

5.3 Service Layer Logic

Method: `CreateAsync(caller, conversationId, kind, payload)` – `AssistantActionService`

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1. New `AssistantPendingAction` (Guid id, `Status = Pending`, `ExpiresAt = now + AssistantActionRules.Lifetime` (10 min), `PayloadJson` = serialized `SendMailPayload` / `UpdateProfilePayload` / `ChangeRolePayload`).
2. `SaveChangesAsync`, audit `"prepared"` (09.4), return the card (`ToCard`).

Method: `ConfirmAsync(caller, id)`

1. `FindForUserAsync(id, userId)` → null → controller returns 404.
2. Pending but `ExpiresAt <= now` → `SetStatusAsync(Expired)`, audit `"expired"`, throw `AssistantActionConflictException` (409).
3. Not pending → 409 ("already been done" for Confirmed, otherwise "can no longer be confirmed ({status})").
4. `AssistantActionRules.Requirement(kind)` → `IAssistantAuthorizer.IsAllowedAsync(principal, policy)`; refused → status `Refused`, audit `"refused"`, store a `Refusal` message, return result with `Status = Refused` (HTTP 200).
5. `TryClaimAsync` (single `ExecuteUpdate` Pending → Confirmed); false → 409 "already been done".
6. `ExecuteAsync`:
   - `SendMail`: re-validate with `SendMailRequestValidator`, `IMailService.SendAsync(userId, request)`.
   - `UpdateOwnProfile`: re-validate with `UpdateOwnProfileRequestValidator`, `IProfileService.UpdateAsync(userId, request)`.
   - `ChangeUserRole`: `IEmployeeService.GetByIdAsync` then `IEmployeeService.UpdateAsync` passing all existing fields (code, name, username, email, project allocations, department ids) with the new `RoleId`.
7. Any exception (except cancellation) → status `Failed`, audit `"failed"`, message `"I could not do that: {reason}. Nothing was sent/changed."` (`reason` = exception message for `AppException` / `ValidationException`, except concurrency/unique errors, otherwise "something went wrong on the server" and logged).
8. Success → audit `"confirmed"` (failure to audit is logged, never turns success into failure); store the reply message; return `AssistantActionResultDto`.

Method: `EditMailAsync(caller, id, request)` – tracked lookup; `EnsurePending` (409 if not pending/expired); only `SendMail` (else 400 "Only a mail can be edited."); validate with `SendMailRequestValidator`; `ResolveRecipientsAsync` (normalised addresses must all be active users, else 400 naming them); replace `PayloadJson`.

Method: `CancelAsync(caller, id)` – if still pending and not expired: `Status = Cancelled`, `ResolvedAt`, audit `"cancelled"`; always returns the current card.

Card building (`ToCard`): a pending action past `ExpiresAt` is shown as `Expired`; titles "Mail draft", "Update your profile", "Change role"; `CanEdit` true only for pending mail.

Tool-level logic

- `AssistantToolbox.DefinitionsForAsync`: advertises only tools whose policy passes for the caller.
- `AssistantToolbox.ExecuteAsync`: unknown tool → message to model; gate refused → audit `"refused"` (action tools) and fixed `Refusal` reply `AssistantTexts.PermissionDenied(description, who)`; arguments must be a JSON object.

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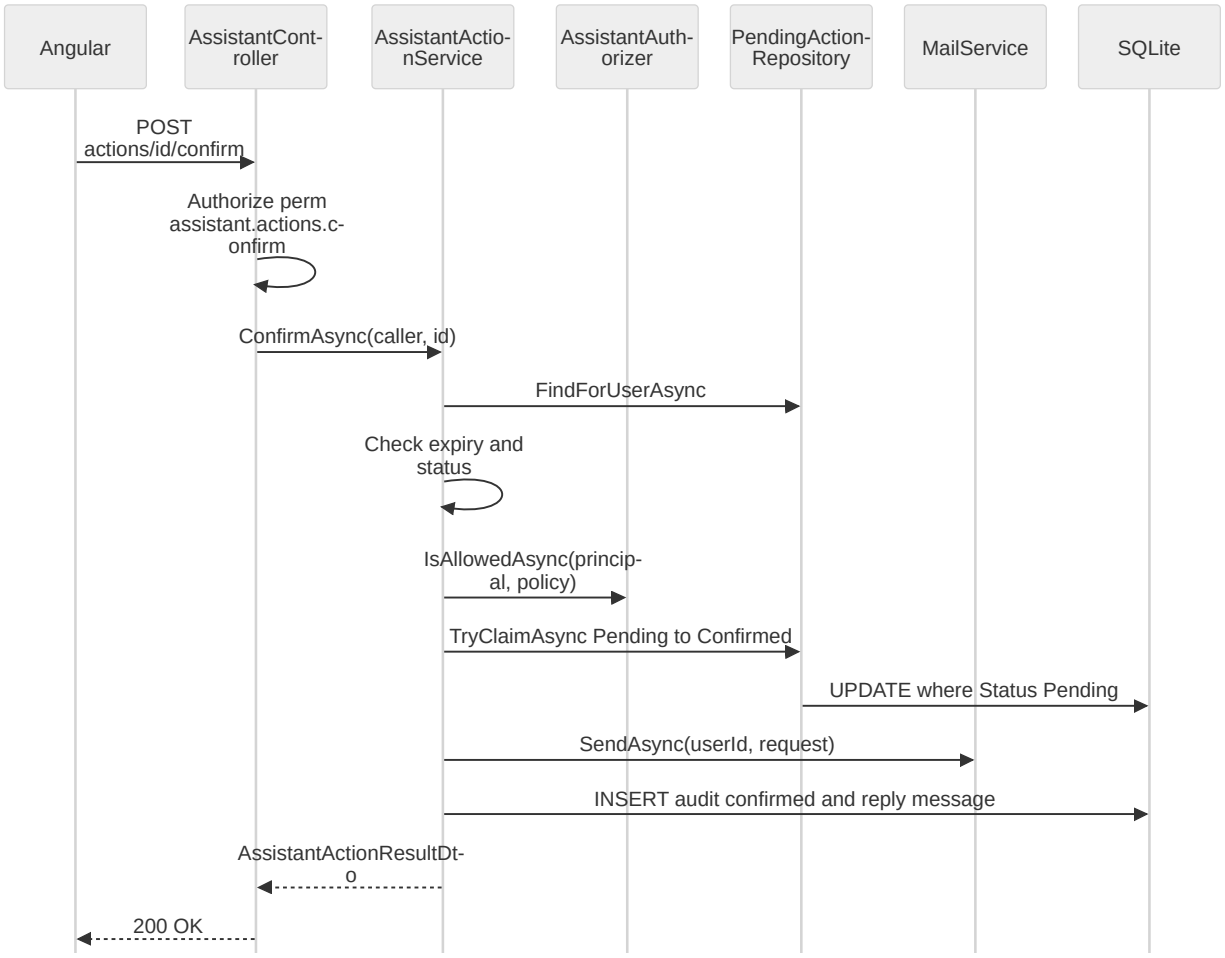
- `AssistantUserResolver.FindAsync`: `@` → exact active email; else exact full name/username (single match wins); else partial `LIKE` (max 5); ambiguity returns candidates.
- `AssistantManagerResolver.ResolveAsync`: with `taskId`, `ITaskService.GetDetailsAsync(id, userId, role)` (null → "That task was not found, or you do not have access to it."); the task creator if different and active; otherwise active users with `RoleId == SystemRoles.ManagerId` managing one of the caller's departments (exactly one required).
- `ProposeProfileUpdateTool`: merges new values with current, validates, checks `EmailUsedByOtherAsync`.
- `ProposeRoleChangeTool`: `FindRoleByNameAsync` (exact name), `FindAsync` user, refuses self, no-op if same role.
- `AssistantTaskReader.OpenTasksAsync`: one `ITaskService.ListAsync` query per open status (ToDo, InProgress, InQA, Blocked), page size 100, at most 5 pages each.
- `TaskPrioritiser.Rank`: exclude Completed/Cancelled; order by stage (Overdue 0, DueToday 1, other 2), local due date, priority desc, deadline, task code.

5.4 Repository Layer

Method	Description	Query Notes
`IAssistantPendingActionRepository.GetForUserAsync(userId, ids)`	Cards for messages	`AsNoTracking`, `UserId` + `ids.Contains`
`FindForUserAsync(id, userId)`	Confirm lookup	`AsNoTracking`, owner filter
`FindForUserForUpdateAsync(id, userId)`	Edit / cancel lookup	Tracked, owner filter
`TryClaimAsync(id, now)`	Atomic Pending → Confirmed	`ExecuteUpdateAsync` with `Status == Pending` filter; returns rows > 0
`SetStatusAsync(id, status, now)`	Set status + `ResolvedAt`	`ExecuteUpdateAsync`
`IAssistantDirectoryRepository.FindActiveAsync / FindActiveByEmailAsync / FindActiveByExactNameAsync / SearchActiveByNameAsync`	Resolve people	Active users only (`IsActive`); soft-deleted hidden by global query filter; `LIKE` with escaped `%`, `_`, `\`
`GetNameAndEmailAsync`, `EmailUsedByOtherAsync`	Profile proposal	Case-insensitive email compare
`FindRoleByNameAsync(name)`	Role lookup	`Roles` exact `Name ==`
`GetDepartmentIdsAsync`, `GetActiveManagersOfDepartmentsAsync`	"My manager"	`UserDepartments`; `RoleId == SystemRoles.ManagerId` and `ManagedDepartments`
`GetActiveRecipientsAsync(lowerEmails)`	Mail edit recipients	Active users by lower-case email

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5.5 Sequence Diagram



6. Database Design

Table	Column	Type	Constraints	Description
`AssistantPendingActions`	`Id`	TEXT (Guid)	PK	Action id
`AssistantPendingActions`	`UserId`	INTEGER	Not Null, FK → `Users.Id`, indexed `IX_AssistantPendingActions_UserId`	Owner
`AssistantPendingActions`	`ConversationId`	INTEGER	Not Null (no FK)	Conversation it belongs to
`AssistantPendingActions`	`Kind`	TEXT(32)	Not Null, enum as string (`SendMail`, `UpdateOwnProfile`, `ChangeUserRole`)	Action type
`AssistantPendingActions`	`PayloadJson`	TEXT	Not Null	Exact payload shown and executed

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Table	Column	Type	Constraints	Description
`AssistantPendingActions`	`Status`	TEXT(16)	Not Null, enum as string (`Pending`, `Confirmed`, `Cancelled`, `Expired`, `Refused`, `Failed`)	State
`AssistantPendingActions`	`CreatedAt`	TEXT (DateTime)	Not Null	UTC
`AssistantPendingActions`	`ExpiresAt`	TEXT (DateTime)	Not Null	CreatedAt + 10 min
`AssistantPendingActions`	`ResolvedAt`	TEXT (DateTime)	Nullable	Set on confirm/cancel/expire/refuse/fail

Read-only lookups (through `AssistantDirectoryRepository`): `Users`, `Roles`, `UserDepartments`, department managers. Confirm and refusal replies are written to `AssistantMessages` (09.1); outcomes to `AssistantAudits` (09.4).

Relationships

- `AssistantPendingActions.UserId → Users.Id` (FK, Cascade)
- `AssistantPendingActions.ConversationId` is a plain column without an FK constraint.

7. Security & Authorization

- **Authorization:** `perm:assistant.actions.confirm` on the three action endpoints. Tools are advertised and gated through `AssistantToolGate` → `IAssistantAuthorizer` (`IAuthorizationService.AuthorizeAsync`) using the same `perm:{key}` policies; `ConfirmAsync` re-checks `AssistantActionRules.Requirement(kind)` with the caller's current token.
- **Data scope:** Own – pending actions are always filtered by `UserId` (another user's id yields 404). Task data used by tools follows the Task Management scope (`ITaskService.ListAsync / GetDetailsAsync(…, userId, role)`). People lookups are limited to active users.
- **Model containment:** the model can only call advertised tools; action tools only create pending actions; refusals and confirmations use fixed text (`AssistantTexts`).
- **Frontend:** action card buttons are not gated by `assistant.actions.confirm` (see Gaps).

Permission Key	Endpoint(s)	UI Element Controlled
`assistant.actions.confirm`	`PUT /api/v1/assistant/actions/{id}`, `POST /api/v1/assistant/actions/{id}/confirm`, `POST /api/v1/assistant/actions/{id}/cancel`	None in UI (Confirm / Edit / Cancel always shown)
`roles.manage`	Tool `propose_role_change`; re-checked in `ConfirmAsync` for `ChangeUserRole`	Tool advertised to the model only when held
`assistant.chat`	Tools run inside `POST /api/v1/assistant/conversation/messages` (09.1)	Action Card visible inside the panel

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8. Validations & Error Handling

Rule	Layer	HTTP Code	Error Message
Action not the caller's / unknown	Controller `RunActionAsync`	404	(empty)
Action expired	`AssistantActionService` (`AssistantActionConflictException`)	409	This request has expired. Please ask TFA again.
Action already done / lost claim	`AssistantActionService`	409	This action has already been done.
Action not pending (confirm)	`AssistantActionService`	409	This action can no longer be confirmed ({status}). Please ask TFA again.
Action not pending (edit)	`AssistantActionService.EnsurePending`	409	This action can no longer be changed. Please ask TFA again.
Edit a non-mail action	`AssistantActionService`	400	Only a mail can be edited.
Edit with invalid mail fields	`SendMailRequestValidator` → `AssistantRequestException`	400	Write a subject or a message before sending. / Add between 1 and 50 recipients. / '{value}' is not an email address.
Edit with non-user recipient	`ResolveRecipientsAsync`	400	These are not active TaskFlow users: {addresses}.
Permission lost at confirm	`AssistantActionService`	200 (`Status = Refused`)	You do not have the required permission to perform this action. {Action} can only be performed by {who}. Please contact your system administrator for assistance.
Execution failure	`AssistantActionService`	200 (`Status = Failed`)	I could not do that: {reason}. Nothing was sent. / Nothing was changed.

409 responses use the problem title `This action can no longer be done`. Angular fallbacks via `apiErrorMessage`: *"Could not confirm that action."*, *"Could not cancel that action."*, *"Could not save your changes."*

9. Integrations / Side Effects

- **Notifications:** none raised directly by TFA. ⚠️ To be confirmed: whether `IMailService.SendAsync` raises a mail notification for recipients (owned by the Communication module).
- **Email:** confirmed `SendMail` actions call `IMailService.SendAsync(userId, SendMailRequest)` – a normal TaskFlow internal mail from the user's mailbox (no attachments, no Cc).

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- **Profile / Employees:** `IProfileService.UpdateAsync` (own name/email); `IEmployeeService.UpdateAsync` (role change; the confirmation text states the target is signed out).
- **Activity Log:** every create / confirm / cancel / expire / refuse / fail writes an `AssistantAudits` row (09.4).
- **Other modules read:** `ITaskService.ListAsync / GetDetailsAsync` (Task Management), `IMailService.GetContactsAsync` (Mail), `IHelpKnowledgeBase` (09.3).

10. Configuration

Key (`appsettings.json`)	Purpose	Default
–	*Not applicable – no configuration keys specific to this child.*	–

Code constants (not configurable): `AssistantActionRules.Lifetime` 10 min; `get_my_tasks` limit default 10 / max 20; `prioritise_tasks` limit default 5 / max 10; `find_user` max 10; `AssistantTaskReader` page size 100, max 5 pages per status. `TaskPrioritiser` uses the application time zone (`Application:Timezone` fallback – see parent).

11. Testing

Test Type	File / Location	Covers
Integration	`tests/TaskFlow.IntegrationTests/Assistant/AssistantEndpointsTests.cs`	Assistant endpoints + authorization (shared with 09.1)
Unit	`tests/TaskFlow.UnitTests/Assistant/Actions/AssistantActionServiceTests.cs`, `AssistantActionConcurrencyTests.cs` (+ `AssistantActionHarness.cs`)	Pending actions, confirm-once
Unit	`tests/TaskFlow.UnitTests/Assistant/Tools/AssistantReadToolsTests.cs`, `AssistantActionToolsTests.cs`	Tools
Unit	`tests/TaskFlow.UnitTests/Assistant/Toolbox/AssistantToolGateTests.cs`	Tool authorization gate
Unit	`tests/TaskFlow.UnitTests/Assistant/Rules/TaskPrioritiserTests.cs`	Ranking

(Coverage descriptions are inferred from file names only.)

12. Known Limitations / Gaps found

- Pending action expiry is evaluated lazily (on read/confirm); no background job marks old actions `Expired`.
- The action card always shows a mail icon and a static "Expires in 10 minutes" label rather than a countdown.

Gaps found

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- **Role change bypasses Employee Management rules:** the REST `PUT /api/v1/users/{id}` (EmployeesController) requires `employees.edit`, plus `employees.role.assign` to change a role, plus `roles.administrator.assign` when moving anyone into or out of Administrator. TFA's `propose_role_change` / `ConfirmAsync` only checks `roles.manage` and calls `IEmployeeService.UpdateAsync` directly, so a custom role holding `roles.manage` but not `employees.role.assign` / `roles.administrator.assign` could change roles (including to Administrator) through TFA. This contradicts `AssistantAuthorizer`'s stated intent that "TFA and the API cannot disagree".
- **`assistant.actions.confirm` not checked in the UI** (also in permission-gaps.md §C): Confirm / Edit / Cancel are shown to users without the key and return 403. permission-gaps.md §F also lists it as a catalog key with no frontend reference (only the constant in `permissions.ts`).
- **"My manager" only finds system Managers:** `GetActiveManagersOfDepartmentsAsync` filters `RoleId == SystemRoles.ManagerId`; department managers in custom roles are ignored. The `AssistantManagerResolver` doc comment says "the single active Manager in the sender's project" while the code uses departments (stale comment).

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